



combat because it offers him a chance to display his courage, to achieve glory for himself, and to uphold his place among his fellows. A man's honour is valued above life itself. The warrior ethic was found among the Plains Indians of North America, the companions of Macedonian conqueror Alexander the Great, and the Vikings of early medieval Scandinavia. It was also encouraged among Luftwaffe fighter pilots in World War II. In some form it is likely to exist among any body of men who are going to perform outstandingly on the battlefield.

SOLDIERS AND WARRIORS

Of course, many fighting men down the ages have entirely lacked enthusiasm for war. When the first hierarchical state systems evolved, around 5,000 years ago, sharp distinctions opened up between the rulers and the ruled, the wealthy and the poor. Making war to extend or defend their empires, rulers pressed men from the lower orders of society into service. Hastily trained and poorly equipped, these troops had a relationship to warfare that was remote from the warrior tradition. An Ancient Egyptian papyrus that has survived from the time of the pharaonic New Kingdom gives this vivid description of the experience of the average soldier: "His march is uphill through mountains. He drinks water every third day; it is smelly and tastes of salt … The enemy comes, surrounds him with missiles, and life recedes from him. He is told: 'Quick, forward, valiant soldier! Win for yourself a good name!' He does not know what he is about. His body is weak, his legs fail him ... If he comes out alive, he is worn out from marching." This was an experience with which many an unwilling foot soldier could identify down the ages.

The warrior ethic still existed in these hierarchical societies, but it became the preserve of the ruling class. Thus, at the same period as the papyrus quoted above, Egyptian pharaohs had themselves depicted in chariots, smiting their enemies with a club, or shooting them with arrows. Fighting was still a prestigious activity, but only when associated with status and power. This was, for example, the attitude of high-status mounted knights in the European Middle Ages, who felt contempt for foot soldiers recruited from the lower ranks of society. The distinction between a warrior and a mere soldier, in



